Sikkim—a land where mountain lakes reflect cobalt blue skies and the torn edges of snow-clad mountains. Amidst swirling mist and sudden rain, the scent of wild herbs and mountain flowers waft in—the source of half-remembered recipes for homely skincare products. In this enchanted land, Rinzing Choden Bhutia, 45, began a journey that would transform her own life, and that of hundreds of women. Raised in the mountains and deeply influenced by traditional healing practices, Rinzing left her corporate job in Delhi and returned to Sikkim, with the desire to build something meaningful using the ways of her land. What began in 2019 as a sustainable homestay project in her husband's village, Kabi, soon evolved into something entirely different. During a visit to a yoga retreat in West Bengal, Rinzing took a course on making organic soaps and other products. The experience lit a spark, but the main objective was to bring positive change to underprivileged women of the state.

Initially, Rinzing began crafting soaps with indigenous herbs, training a small group of women, and the venture, called Agapi ('love' in Greek), started taking shape in Gangtok. Hers was a bootstrap effort, and she remembers the determination of all partners. As a fledgling business grew steadily, the COVID pandemic struck, stalling her homestay for two years, but leaving her with the time to explore new processes and products and develop Agapi further. "I started in my kitchen. Moved on to have a studio. Now we have a manufacturing unit in Sikkim," Rinzing recalls with pride. In 2022, her friend Varsha Srestha, also 45, joined the venture, later becoming a co-founder in 2023, when Rinzing incorporated Trateng Greens Pvt. Ltd, under which Agapi operates.

Around the same time, Agapi participated in a CSR challenge organised by Japanese social impact investors ARUN Seed. They did not win, but its president Satoko Kono reached out to Rinzing afterwards. She seized the opportunity and convinced Kono to invest, resulting in an unexpected foreign direct investment (FDI) for Agapi—a milestone that opened doors for other women entrepreneurs in the Northeast. By 2024–25, the brand recorded a turnover of Rs 50 lakh.

Agapi has now become a benchmark for ethical and sustainable skincare from the Northeast, using ingredients abundantly available in the Himalayan region—mugwort, rhododendron, hemp, hibiscus, coffee, tea, orange peel and more. Its oils, cleansing oils, scrubs, lip balms, creams, soaps and bath salts make for a complete range of products.

In Kabi, along with the skill development department of the Sikkim government, Rinzing started training women in 2019, many of whom have gone on to start their own enterprises. In all, she has trained 500 women. Agapi regularly takes on interns from IIM Shillong and local Sikkim colleges, offering them small stipends. "I believe that we can bring in change if we impart knowledge to others. Which is why I encourage interns and trainees," she says. "Also, as a micro entrepreneur, I have received immense support from the Sikkim government." Recently, an intern from Manipur found safe haven with Agapi during the height of the sectarian violence there.

Agapi products are sold online, and at select outlets in Sikkim. Rinzing and her team are now building the first Agapi flagship store in Gangtok. ■

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RINZING CHODEN BHUTIA

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Trateng Greens Pvt. Ltd, Brand name: Agapi

What they do
Make organic skincare products from herbs, flowers and other ingredients

Founded in: 2023

Annual turnover
Rs 50 lakh